years, India was connected to the world and could not help but be involved in and affected by global and regional developments.

The external dynamics did bind India's options, but they also created opportunities for Indian policymakers. They were not passive spectators and sought to shape their environment. And they used the Cold War and American fears after the "loss" of China for India's benefit—including by eliciting military and economic aid from Washington and getting the US to serve as a frontline state when they faced a China challenge.

The Cold War in this one sense benefited India. Its importance to both Moscow and Washington derived in no small part from the superpower competition. One cannot answer the counterfactual about whether India would have been as important to them in the absence of the Cold War, but one cannot take it as a given that these countries would have seen it to be in their interest to invest heavily in India absent their competition.

That superpower rivalry, and the related geopolitical and ideological contest between China and India, indeed made India less peripheral to the US than was earlier believed. Some have asserted that "Americans seldom regarded India as special. Their prior perceptions did not place India on the same plane as China. Few appreciated the value to American interests of a strong, independent and nonaligned India."[10] It is true that India moved up and down the US priority list, but this book shows that there was a significant period of time when the US did see India as special and sought to build and support a strong India.

And Indian foreign policymakers, in turn, realized that for defense and development, India had to seek a little (military and economic) help from its friends. Autonomy could not be the primary goal, and at times the two more important objectives—security and prosperity—even meant seeking alignment.

India tilted twice during the period this book covers: 1962–1963, when India sought American aid against China, and the two countries signed an air defense agreement that called for mutual consultations in the event of a Chinese attack against India; and 1971, when, with a looming China-Pakistan threat, India signed a treaty with the Soviet Union that envisioned mutual consultations if either country was attacked. These Indian alignments took place when five elements coincided: an imminent threat; India's inability to deal with the challenge on its own; a willing partner; the